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Social Science and the Policy-Making Process

by BRUCE JENNINGS and DANIEL CALLAHAN

In recent years the social sciences have been called upon to play multifaceted roles in the policy-making process. So varied are these roles that it is futile to talk about the use of social science in policy making *simpliciter* as if there were one constant relationship between two fixed and stable entities. Instead, to address this issue sensibly, one must talk about the uses of different modes of social scientific inquiry for different kinds of policies under various circumstances.

In some cases, the influence of social scientific research is direct and tangible, and the connection between the findings and the policy is easy to see. For example, the statistical and social scientific analyses of data generated by the census, the Bureau of Labor Statistics, and similar government surveys are the bases upon which a wide variety of legislative and administrative decisions are made. Similarly influential have been large-scale social surveys directed at specific policy issues, such as the studies of educational policy conducted by the sociologist James Coleman.

However, in other (perhaps most) cases, the influence of social scientific research on policy is indirect—one small piece in a larger mosaic of politics, bargaining, and compromise. Occasionally, as with the Coleman studies, the findings of social scientific research are explicitly drawn upon by policy makers in the formation, implementation, or evaluation of particular policies. More often, as Charles E. Lindblom and David K. Cohen and others have taken pains to point out, the categories and theoretical models of social science have an indirect bearing on policy by providing a general background orientation within which policy makers conceptualize problems and frame policy options.[1] At times, the influence of social scientific work is cognitive and informational in nature; in other instances, policy makers use social science primarily for symbolic and political purposes in order to legitimate pre-established goals and strategies. This latter situation is probably inevitable in our own or any other political system, but many social scientists—particularly those who have been bloodied by their occasional forays into the political arena—find it deeply disturbing because it seems to compromise the intellectual integrity of the social sciences.

Nonetheless, amid this diversity, troubling general questions persistently arise and these became a central part of our project. They concern the epistemological validity of social scientific knowledge and its applicability, the proper relationship between the social scientist and the policy maker, and the balance that must be struck between the empirical and normative components of political decision making in a democratic society. These questions are not new. For three centuries, beginning with Thomas Hobbes, they have been intertwined with a strand of modern political thought that predicated stable, effective government on the application of a science of human behavior. But in recent years these questions have once again come to the fore, following a period in the 1960s and 1970s when it began to look as if Hobbes's dream of a scientifically based governance was finally becoming a practical possibility.

In order to understand why these questions about the use of social scientific knowledge in public policy making are being raised today, it was necessary to trace the development of social scientific policy analysis. In principle, applied social science can take on a variety of forms and can have a variety of consequences depending upon the way the scientific enterprise is understood, the nature of the policy-making institutions themselves, and the tenor of the relationship between policy makers and researchers. In the United States, the specific content of each of these factors has shaped the "career" of applied social science and has, in turn, shaped our perception of the methodological, political, and ethical problems associated with it. Accordingly, in the project we devoted a good deal of attention to the historical background of the problems we discussed. The following sketch, though overly brief and incomplete, provides some sense of the historical context that framed our discussions of the issues.

Although their intellectual origins may be traced back to thinkers like Hobbes and to eighteenth-century social reformers like Jeremy Bentham and Cesare Beccaria, the modern notion of a scientific study of social processes and human behavior did not fully emerge until late in the nineteenth century with the work of major figures such as Emile Durkheim and Max Weber. Despite important differences in method and emphasis, both Durkheim and Weber, together with economists like Alfred Marshall and psychologists like John B. Watson and Sigmund Freud, stressed the ways in which the study of human behavior could become as "scientific" as the study of physics and biology. Durkheim and Weber also believed that the findings drawn from a scientific study of society could be of tremendous value in coming to grips with the new problems that were emerging from the development of capitalism and the industrial revolution.

In Weber, and even in Durkheim, this prospect of the practical benefits to be derived from the advance of social scientific knowledge was tinged by a dark foreboding about

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the ultimate future of the modern world. Characteristically, those American thinkers who were eager to reap the practical benefits of modern social science were considerably more optimistic. The linkage between social science and social reform came to the United States rather early with the creation of the American Social Science Association in 1865. Its purpose was:

> to aid the development of Social Science and to guide the public mind to the best practical means of promoting the Amendment of Laws, the Advancement of Education, the Prevention and Repression of Crime, the Reformation of Criminals, the Progress of Public Morality, the Adoption of Sanitary Regulations, and the Diffusion of Sound Principles on the Questions of Economy, Trade, and Finance. It will give attention to Pauperism and the topics related thereto . . . (it will aim to obtain) by discussion the real elements of Truth; by which doubts are removed, conflicting opinions harmonized, and a common ground afforded for treating wisely the great social problems of the day.[2]

Several decades later, when the first graduate department of sociology was established at Columbia University in 1894, it announced in a similar vein that "it is becoming more and more apparent that industrial and social progress is bringing the modern community face to face with social questions of the greatest magnitude, the solution of which will demand the best scientific study and the most honest practical endeavor . . . ."[3]

During the period between the turn of the century and the end of the First World War, American social science continued to remain closely linked with the Progressive movement and the practical goals of social reform. However, during this same period a new phase in the development of American social science was beginning to emerge. That phase emphasized a greater concern with the refinement of empirical research techniques—particularly social surveys and sampling—and with improved methodological rigor. Quantitative survey techniques first developed in England by Charles Booth gained a wide following among American social scientists during the 20s and 30s, and this was given further impetus by the interest that American corporations and radio broadcasters were beginning to take in market surveys and consumer research. Indeed, it was with work done for the private sector, rather than with research related to public policy making, that applied social science in America first came into its own.

Thus during these years a wedge was driven between applied social science and Progressive social reform movements, and a process that can best be described as the professionalization of social science began. This process of

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professionalization, which would eventually produce the tension between what James Coleman has called "disciplinary social science" and "policy research,"[4] was set in motion by the creation of the Social Science Research Council in 1923. In its early work the SSRC gave priority to the development of a rigorous, positivistically oriented social scientific methodology.

As it has turned out, this early process of professionalization has resulted in a rather ironic legacy. The entry of social scientists into the policy-making process has largely been due to the belief that they possess a special kind of expert knowledge otherwise unavailable to other policy makers and advisors—e.g., lawyers and administrators—who have not been trained in the social sciences. The credibility of this special expertise, in turn, has been predicated on a positivistic belief that social science can explain and predict patterns of social behavior with enough accuracy to suggest effective and efficient means to the attainment of given policy objectives. At the same time, however, the professionalization of social science has led to the creation of research norms and professional reward systems that often lead social scientists to be either indifferent to or suspicious of the political pressures of the policy-making process and the concrete time-pressured needs of policy makers. In short, the same disciplinary norms and professional credentials that make social scientists credible in the eyes of policy makers in the first place often lead to severe strains and conflicts when social scientists and policy makers actually try to work together in the policy-making process.

The growth of governmental programs during the New Deal and World War II rekindled considerable interest in the application of social scientific knowledge to public policy making. However, the enthusiasm for applied social science reached its high point during the early and mid-1960s. Social scientific data, theories, and methodologies began, rather suddenly, to be called upon for policy-related purposes with a new sense of urgency and purpose. Their contribution took two principal forms: policy analysis and aggregate social survey studies. Administrative reforms undertaken first in the Department of Defense during the McNamara years and then directives mandating planning, programming, and budgeting systems (PPBS) swept across the entire federal bureaucracy, creating new openings for policy analysis. Congress began to specify evaluation studies as an intrinsic part of social programs. Federal agencies shifted monies from university-based grant research to more specified, policy-oriented contract research increasingly conducted by large research firms (e.g., Abt Associates, American Institutes of Research, Stanford Research Institute, System Development Corporation, and The Rand Corporation). Social scientists armed with sophisticated micro-economic theories and models, systems theory, decision theory, cost-benefit analysis, and the like quickly responded to this opportunity. The creation of new graduate programs of policy analysis at major universities helped to institutionalize policy analysis as a principal channel through which particular components of social scientific research flowed—and continue to flow—into the policy arena. Concomitantly, the civil rights movement, anti-poverty programs, and concern with urban problems created a second opening for applied social science, this time in the form of large-scale empirical studies.

New Questions about Applied Social Science

Looking back on this period, one is struck by the speed with which the social sciences—principally economics but also psychology, sociology, and political science—rose to a prominent place in the policy process. Even more striking were the largely unexamined and unchallenged presuppositions that had actually been questioned by earlier social scientists. Included among them were: (1) a conception of policy making as a primarily "administrative" or "technical" undertaking; (2) a belief that the social scientist's role in the policy process is to provide instrumental, "value-free" advice concerning efficient means to achieve pre-established ends; and (3) an underlying positivistic account of the nature of social science itself. These three presuppositions were, for a time, interlocking and mutually reinforcing. When their interconnection began to unravel and when each began to come under critical scrutiny from various quarters, many lingering or submerged questions about policy analysis and the political role of the social sciences could no longer be held in abeyance.

Speaking to the White House Economic Conference in 1962, President John F. Kennedy articulated a then widely held view of the challenge facing government in the United States:

> The fact of the matter is that most of the problems, or at least many of them that we now face, are technical problems, are administrative problems. They are very sophisticated judgments which do not lend themselves to the great sort of "passionate movements" which have stirred this country so often in the past. Now they deal with questions which are beyond the comprehension of most men.[5]

These remarks succinctly express the first presupposition mentioned above, and they convey as well the climate of opinion that came to dominate the attitude of American policy makers in the 1960s and 70s. Underlying the President's formulation here—which, by the way, reflected views being expressed by many prominent social scientists during this period as part of the so-called "end of ideology" thesis—was the belief that a stable normative or ideological consensus had finally been achieved in the United States. That consensus assumed an era of unlimited economic growth and centered on the basic tenets of welfare state liberalism: the extension of civil liberties to previously disenfranchised groups, equality of opportunity, and the provision of a minimum floor of social welfare entitlements. Under these conditions, political "issues" gave way to or

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became administrative "problems" amenable to technical "solutions." Normative debates about ends could be put aside in favor of purportedly much more rational and manageable factual debates about means. Freed from the perturbations of the great passionate movements of the past, governmental decision making could concern itself with questions of efficiency and the fitting of means to ends. Knowing where we wanted to go, our only problem was how to get there.

Moreover, once policy making was taken to be primarily an administrative, technical activity, cut off from broadly normative or ideological considerations and concerned solely with the efficient fitting of means to ends already given, a particular conception of the relationship between the social scientist (or policy analyst) and the policy maker became appropriate. The social scientist was cast in a normatively passive—objective or value-neutral—role. Having been assigned a particular goal by the policy maker (who, in turn, was acting on authority delegated by democratically elected representatives), the social scientist was to analyze particular policy options which, on the basis of empirically confirmed generalizations about human behavior, could be evaluated in terms of their potential consequences, the relationship between costs and benefits, and their likely effectiveness.

Here the final presupposition mentioned above came into play. A broadly positivistic conception of the nature of social science dovetailed quite nicely with the notion of policy making as technical problem solving and with the normatively passive role of the social scientist vis-à-vis the policy maker. Indeed, on this conception social scientists could hardly play any role but this if their activities were to be intellectually honest and politically legitimate. To claim special expertise and authoritative knowledge regarding matters of fact was precisely what the social scientist qua scientist was supposed to do and could do now that the social sciences had reached a certain stage of intellectual maturity. But to claim expertise and authority regarding matters of value was unwarranted. Thus, during this period, the belief that policy questions were technical questions and the positivist belief that the social sciences, by emulating the empirical methodologies of the natural sciences, could provide expert factual and instrumental knowledge needed for the solution to these problems converged to create a powerful intellectual rationale for the rapid rise of applied social science.

Within the confines of these presuppositions, the ethical questions pertinent to the use of social science in policy making are quite limited and tend to merge with the canons of professional scientific methodology. Given this general understanding of the situation, intellectual honesty, the suppression of personal bias, careful collection and accurate reporting of data, and candid admission of the limits of the scientific reliability of studies—these were essentially the only ethical questions that could arise. And, since these ethical responsibilities are not particularly controversial (at least in principle), it is not surprising that during this period neither those concerned with ethics nor social scientists themselves devoted much time to analyzing or discussing them. Simultaneously, ethical questions in a broader sense, like the disturbingly antidemocratic implications of the view that governance had become something to be left to technical experts—because, in President Kennedy's words, it dealt with "questions which are beyond the comprehension of most men"—were largely neglected as well.

To be sure, this brief account of the climate of opinion that prevailed while policy analysis and applied social science rose to prominence in American government is drastically oversimplified. But it is not, we believe, fundamentally misleading. The presuppositions we have mentioned are still to be found, albeit in more sophisticated forms, in a good deal of the current literature on policy analysis; they surfaced on more than one occasion during our project. However, in the last few years discussions of policy analysis have begun to appear that challenge many of these presuppositions and that raise once again some long-neglected epistemological, political, and ethical questions concerning the use of social scientific inquiry in public policy making.

Those questions have been receiving increasing attention recently for two principal reasons. First, the positivistic account of the nature of social scientific knowledge has come under sustained attack. In particular, the positivist account of objectivity and its insistence on a sharp separation of facts and values has been rendered problematic by recent philosophical analyses of science. It is also now becoming clear, and widely recognized, that even the most quantitative and formalistic policy-analytic techniques contain concealed value choices and inextricable normative implications. Second, and equally important, historical and sociological studies of the interaction between social scientists and policy makers—and of the ways social scientific studies have actually been used in policy settings—have shown that this interaction is a good deal more complex and problematic than had previously been thought. These studies have indicated that the direct impact of social science on policy outcomes is usually very slight, that the indirect influence of generally circulated social scientific theories and concepts may be the social sciences' most telling contribution, and that the actual dynamics of policy making render it anything but a merely administrative or technical undertaking.

Policy Analysis in the 80s: New Challenges and Debates

These considerations suggest that policy analysis and applied social science are now entering a period in which they face a challenging—but also potentially creative and revitalizing—reassessment of their role in the intellectual and practical life of our society. Prompted equally by new philosophical investigations of the epistemological foundations of social science, and by reflection upon past experiences

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with the use of social science in policy making, this reassessment will open the way for a concerted and detailed discussion of the ethical responsibilities of social scientists as policy advisors. But as this discussion of the ethics of social inquiry proceeds, it will—and should—be accompanied by a series of broader questions. What kind of knowledge do the social sciences offer, and how does it differ from the knowledge and perspectives generated by other areas of professional expertise and specialization? What kind of validity does social scientific knowledge possess? What kind of questions can the social sciences ask? What kind of answers can they provide? How can social scientists work effectively in the policy-making process? How direct a role ought they play? However one eventually answers these difficult questions, we have come to the conclusion that the ethical responsibilities of social scientists as policy advisors can neither be well defined nor clearly understood apart from the context of these broader epistemological, political, and organizational concerns.

In the project, we and the other participants attempted to come to grips with the full spectrum of these issues. Our discussions tended to center on five main themes. One theme, of course, was the question of ethical guidelines pertinent to the practice of policy analysis and the use of applied social research. Warwick and Pettigrew undertook to define the key ethical problems raised by the relationship between social science and public policy, and they suggested ethical guidelines designed to alert applied researchers to the morally sensitive aspects of their work.

The second main theme involved basic ethical and political questions about the nature of social scientific knowledge and its proper use in a democratic society. As a start, we carefully reviewed various aspects of contemporary critiques of positivistic social science. Some of these critiques—such as those of Lindblom and Cohen and Aaron Wildavsky—stress the ways in which positivism has claimed too much for the certainty and authoritativeness that social scientific knowledge can achieve. They advocate a more limited and humble role for social science both in the overall scheme of our culture and in the inherently pluralistic, incremental policy-making process, a role in which social science would stand alongside, but not try to exclude, more everyday, commonsensical, and politically sensitive modes of knowledge and experience. We found the basic thrust of these critiques to be widely shared today, both among disciplinary social scientists and policy analysts. Indeed, the latter felt a certain amount of relief as the more weighty and unrealistic demands of the positivistic legacy were lifted from their shoulders; but for all that, there remained a vestigial uneasiness about exactly how a compelling case for social scientific policy analysis could be made on this new, more modest, basis.

Other critiques of positivistic social science that we discussed operate at a somewhat more abstract level of analysis, and they contain more radical—and hence more controversial—implications. These critiques—such as those of Jurgen Habermas and Richard Bernstein—focus on the political and ideological assumptions that they take to be inherent in the positivistic conception of social science itself. Here the argument is that the very idea of applied social science necessarily reinforces the dominant ideology of an administrative, technocratic state, where social engineering and the efficient manipulation of human "objects" are the order of the day. Needless to say, we found this line of argument extremely controversial, and, more disturbing, we discovered that those who have developed their critique of positivism along those lines have not attempted to specify how the nonpositivistic modes of social inquiry they favor might be specifically pertinent to public policy analysis and debate, if at all. Accordingly, we attempted to bridge the gap between these very general critiques of positivism and the concrete problems of the use of social science in policy analysis by exploring new modes of policy analysis that might follow from these critiques.

Some project participants argued that "interpretative" or "practical" modes of social scientific analysis would serve as a better basis for policy analysis than more positivistic or "technological" modes of social science. They argued against the elitism and the purported value neutrality of technological social science and against its instrumental conception of knowledge and rationality. In a democratic society, they argued, social inquiry should be a part of a larger, participatory form of life based on the exercise of practical reason and moral judgment. Further, they argued that the relationship between the social scientist and the persons studied should be one of mutual learning and respect rather than one of calculated manipulation and control, and that interpretative approaches to social science are more compatible with this sort of desired relationship between the knower and the known.

Other project participants argued on the contrary that even interpretative modes of social science are not immune to antidemocratic ideological manipulation. Indeed, a few project participants went still further, arguing that any attempt to apply nonpositivistic modes of social science to policy making in a liberal capitalistic state faces severe, perhaps insurmountable dangers of co-optation and ideological distortion. Finally, arguing something of a middle position on the issue, some participants suggested that the interpretative mode of social science be turned on the policy-making process itself. If social scientists cannot effectively mediate between the policy maker and "social reality"—and perhaps they should not try to do so—then at least they can help the policy maker become more conscious of and critical toward the various perceptual frameworks that do inevitably shape his or her understanding of that reality.

A third area of concentration for discussions during the project was an historical assessment of the political contributions that have been made by works coming out of various traditions of social inquiry. We considered first the

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British tradition of social administration, a mode of social science self-consciously devoted to a normative program of social reform, much as American social science had been in the early part of the twentieth century. Unlike American Progressivism, however, one important stream of the British social administration tradition has retained its viability. American policy studies in the postwar period have moved in an altogether different direction, emphasizing their detachment from any one ideological program or political party, and, as previously noted, cultivating their professional status and methodological rigor.

Thus British and American styles of policy research offered us an interesting case study of contrasting orientations. Many project participants argued that British work tended to be empirically and methodologically weaker than similar American research, but that in many cases the British studies were more interesting, relevant, and suggestive to policy makers. Wherever possible, of course, everyone agreed that methodological rigor should be combined with policy relevance and moral sensitivity. The problem arises, however, when rigor and relevance seem to be at odds. The fact that this frequently happens poses one of the most serious ethical dilemmas for applied social scientists in their relationship with policy makers.

Looking at a different tradition of twentieth-century social science—the ethnographic studies that grew out of the Chicago School of Sociology—we discussed the use of research on marginal, deviant, or oppressed groups as the basis for policy advocacy on behalf of these groups. Our discussion focused on one particular problem associated with advocacy research: namely, that as these groups become politically self-conscious and organized, the social scientist's access to them is dependent upon ideological sympathy and favorable reporting and that this compromises the ideal of scientific objectivity. Early proponents of advocacy research thought that merely calling attention to the plight of marginal groups would effectively lead to policies beneficial to them. As it became clear that effective advocacy required more than mere publicity or visibility, however, the line between sociological advocacy and political action began to blur. In recent years, few social scientists have been able or willing to play both the role of scholar and activist, and the genre of advocacy research has markedly declined.

A fourth theme of our project discussions involved recent sociological studies of the role of social scientific advisors in the policy-making process. With the assistance of a number of the leading researchers in this field, we surveyed these studies carefully and generally came to the following conclusions. First, the influence of the social sciences is mainly indirect, and the relationship between social scientists and policy makers is beset by mutual misunderstandings and cross-purposes. Second, in order to understand why this is so and to develop realistic expectations about the roles that social science can play, the complexity of the policy process must be fully appreciated. Third, and finally, we need better models of the policy process itself in order to meet this need.

The fifth theme of the project focused on the differences between disciplinary social science and policy analysis. In discussing those differences we tried to explore the ethical implications that these differences hold for those engaged in policy analysis. Some project participants insisted upon contrasting social science and policy analysis very sharply in terms of the methodological criteria appropriate to each. The exacting methods and standards of disciplinary social science cannot and should not be carried over into the domain of policy analysis, they argued, because the purposes served by these standards in academic inquiry—the advance of general and social knowledge and the refinement of existing paradigmatic theories—are not pertinent to the policy analyst's task. The policy analyst must make specific recommendations about particular problems; his or her function is to enhance the rationality of the policy maker's choice rather than to advance general theoretical knowledge of society. Hence, the studies conducted by a policy analyst must be accommodated to the constraints of the policy setting, even if this means that they fail to live up to the currently prevailing canons of disciplinary rigor.

Arguing against this position, other participants maintained that it is precisely because disciplinary standards do not fit easily into the policy maker's work that policy analysis should not be thought of as an autonomous enterprise with its own rules. By remaining faithful to the canons of disciplinary rigor, they argued, policy analysts can make their greatest contribution by questioning the policy maker's preconceptions. Policy analysts, in their view, should challenge the constraints and premises of the policy process so as to make it more open to new considerations and perspectives.

It is not easy to convey the flavor of a project or its meetings. What became clear as we proceeded is that the five principal issues we returned to time and again are now open questions within the social sciences and public policy analysis. Perhaps they are the kind of questions that do not admit to definitive resolution. They may, instead, simply represent alternative visions and styles, each subject to valid criticism if taken too far, but each of continuing fruitfulness as long as it remains in tension with the others.

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